

7.1 INTRODUCTION

The World Health Organisation(WHO) estimates that about 75% of deaths in people over the age of 65 in industrialized countries are from heart diseases, cancer and cerebrovascular disease. Millions of senior citizen across the globe are not getting proper healthcare they need because government and the society are not aware enough of the problem by 2026, there will be about 1200 million people aged 65 years according to un estimates. 7% of the 1.1 million Indian population is today over the age of 60.

The lifespan for both male (>65 years) and female (75 years) has raised significantly and it is estimated that by the turn of this century, numerically the highest number of old people will be in India.

Nurses and health professionals therefore have to be aware of the complexity of the care of elder people.

7.2 DEFINITION

Old age is a universal problem and is a community need. This is not a disease to be cured. It is a stage where people need to be protected from accidents, infections and disabilities. According to Sir Jamessterling.

Greek: genu = old age

Latera = treatment

Geriatrics : A branch of medicine that deals with the problems and disease of old age and aging peoples.

Gerontology: Comprehensive study of aging and the problems of the aged

Old age : Period of life when impairment of physical and mental functions becomes increasingly manifested in comparison to the previous years of life.

7.3 AGEING PROCESS

The ageing process is the gradual, decreased ability of the body to functions and to heal itself.

As our body age, they naturally deteriorate in the late years, many essential functions begin operating at a suboptimal level.

There are three main factors that influence the body's ageing process.

First as we grow older, the number of mistake incurred by daily Cellular reproduction increases. The body actually create non-functional cells, leading to more rapid deteriorate of the body's functions with advantage age. A large percentage of our cells even through they were present are useless. These non-functional cells sometime interfere with normal cellular process.

The second part of the ageing process related to Cellular damage that cause the shortening of DNA. As time passes increased damage to healthy DNA leeds to accelerated cell death and our old bodies simply cannot generate cells fast enough to compensate for the loss. This process is most visible and obvious in

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